

SHAILESH KAVAL



**HOLY TRIAL:** Lord Ganesha as a judge

## Prayer for a Daughter

**A vigorous campaign against female foeticide targets communities traditionally hostile to girls**

■ By Uday Mahurkar

In Ahmedabad's Dariapur area this year the Ganesh Mahotsav was celebrated with the usual fervour but with a social message: "Down with female foeticide, save the girl child." The idol of Lord Ganesha sat as a judge over a case of female foeticide with the parents of the dead girl child standing as accused in the trial box. In another village, Devaliya, people from the Patel community, notoriously hostile to the girl child, were led by a diamond magnate, Mathur Savani, in burning the effigy of Ravan, symbolising an end to the very thought of killing the girl child in the mother's womb.

With *Beti Bachao Andolan*—a term coined by Chief Minister Narendra Modi—gaining momentum, social mindset is changing in Gujarat, a state which had one of the poorest sex ratios in the country. From 802 in 2001 and 822 in 2002, the sex ratio has climbed to over 870 in 2007 in the state, against a national average of 933. The worst affected tehsil in the state, Unjha, in Mehsana district, has witnessed the most encouraging climb—from 742 in 2001 to 863 this year.

The drive started taking root nearly four years back, when the penchant for a male child led to a situation where



there were no girls left in the Patel and the Chaudhary communities for their boys to marry. There were also reports of young boys of marriageable age visiting brothels. The campaign took the shape of a movement early last year when Savani's Saurashtra Jaldhara Trust, an NGO, organised a massive anti-female foeticide rally—led by state Education Minister

Anadiben Patel—in Surat in which 12 lakh people took a vow against killing the female foetus and exposing anybody who did so. A booklet on the ill-effects of the practice was dispatched to 35 lakh couples. Says Savani, "Our campaign aims at bringing about a fundamental change in outlook." Two imaginative letters—one written by a dead girl child to her mother from heaven asking what her fault was and the other, a mother's moving response—were also distributed.

The campaign has had an impact. Says Kunvarjibhai Patel, a farmer in Kukavav village in Saurashtra, "My daughter was taunted by her mother-in-law as she had two daughters and no son. Thanks to the booklet, she is a changed woman today." Dinesh Patel, a medical shop owner in Jamnagar, gave up the idea of getting their third girl child aborted, in his wife's womb, after going through the booklet. Clearly, Gujarat's *Beti Bachao* campaign has a lesson for the entire country.